

Beat Goes On

Recreating poet Allen Ginsberg's Indian experience



A BLUE HAND: THE BEATS IN INDIA
by DEBORAH BAKER
Penguin/Viking
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 226

■ By Dilip Bobb

Howl!, Allen Ginsberg's epic poem, became the anthem for an entire generation and, along with Jack Kerouac and William Burroughs, he created the Beat Generation, or The Beats. They were a motley group, artists, writers, groupies—many of them head cases—but all immersed in counter-culture and an anti-establishment stance. They pretty much looked the same as well: scruffy, dishevelled, addicted to one form of narcotic or another and forever in search of enlightenment. It was a utopian, often drug-fuelled search that literally became a rite of passage.

This was what brought Ginsberg and some of his gang to India. They spent 15 months alternating between Himalayan ashrams, fleabag hotels in cities like Calcutta, and getting stoned amid the funeral pyres of Benaras. Their search for instant nirvana was tragic-comic but has not been well-documented till now. *A Blue Hand*, referring to a hallucinatory Ginsberg moment, is the work of biographer Deborah Baker, whose extensive research allows her to recreate that spiritual odyssey. Baker, who is married to author Amitav Ghosh, brings that utopian era and the Beat Generation back to life. The book traces their origins and their icons, their excessive lifestyles through drugs, mostly LSD, and sexual adventurism. Above all, she manages to capture their artistic and spiritual obsessions as well as their pettiness, their tantrums and the reality of their existence. It's a scholarly work with Ginsberg's Indian sojourn as its centre-piece but it's also about an era that is long forgotten and about an American icon who sacrificed his creative potential for drugs and illusions. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The 3 Mistakes of My Life	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa
2. (3)	Brida	Paulo Coelho	HarperCollins
3. (2)	A Prisoner of Birth	Jeffrey Archer	Pan Macmillan
4. (4)	Sea of Poppies	Amitav Ghosh	Penguin
5. (5)	Unaccustomed Earth	Jhumpa Lahiri	Random House

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (3)	The Last Lecture	Randy Pausch and Jeffrey Zaslow	Hodder & Stoughton
3. (5)	Cold Steel	Tim Bouquet and Byron Ousey	Little, Brown
4. (6)	The Post American World	Fareed Zakaria	Penguin
5. (2)	The Greatness Guide 2	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (-)	The White Tiger	Aravind Adiga	HarperCollins
9. (16)	The Enchantress of Florence	Salman Rushdie	Jonathan Cape
11. (13)	Shantaram	Gregory David Roberts	Penguin
12. (-)	Six Suspects	Vikas Swarup	DoubleDay
19. (9)	A Case of Exploding Mangoes	Mohammed Hanif	Random House

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
7. (7)	Go Kiss the World	Subroto Bagchi	Penguin
10. (9)	Chicken Soup for the Indian Soul	Jack Canfield	Westland
11. (-)	India After Gandhi: The History of the World's Largest Democracy	Ramachandra Guha	Picador
13. (-)	Romancing with Life	Dev Anand	Penguin
14. (15)	Billions of Entrepreneurs	Tarun Khanna	Penguin/Viking

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead